

The Department of Defense and its Correspondence Relationship with Legislators

PS 699: Independent Study (Spring 2020)

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7 items left to do

Introduction

Literature Review

Theory

Design

Data

Altogether we have 7635 letters received by the Department of Defense that are marked as “congressional” from 2007-2017. All of these letters are from Members of the U.S. Congress. Note: During my independent study, I handcoded approximately 3,492 letters from a variety of Department of Defense agencies. Unfortunately, we were not able to implement these observations into the final data set. Thus, observations that are missing a Policy Type Category have a current Type of NA.

A Potential Outlier

In this analysis, Senator Grassley (R-IA) is considered to be an outlier. He wrote 188 letters to the Department of Defense, the most out of any other members of congress. However, he was never a part of any committee that actively work for the Department of Defense. Although at this point, we are unable to see what are the policy categories of the letters he wrote to the Department of Defense, based off of the hand-coding I did, Grassley wrote a majority of his letters on behalf of constituents, specifically for Veterans in Iowa. On further analysis, Grassley’s campaign has largely been based on providing veterans in Iowa opportunities to present their legacy to other residents in Iowa and the US, and more within the realm of congressional agencies, aid with ensuring that veterans receive their benefits after retiring or being discharged from the military. These benefits include disability compensation, education programs, health benefits, and more. A majority of these concerns would be best addressed via the Department of Veteran Affairs versus most of the Department of Defense agencies, however, many of the issues, such as Military Pay complaints as well as sexual harrassment allegations can indeed be addressed with the Department of Defense agencies, such as the Department of Defense and Accounting Service (DFAS) as well as the Office of the Inspector General, U.S. Department of Defense (DOD_OIG). Thus, at this time, I am not considering Senator Grassley to be an outlier in my analysis.

Table 1: Top Policy Categories within Grassley’s Letters to the DOD

bioname	party	TYPE	cqlabel	n
GRASSLEY, Charles Ernest	(R)	NA	(IA)	168
GRASSLEY, Charles Ernest	(R)	1	(IA)	19
GRASSLEY, Charles Ernest	(R)	5	(IA)	1

Top 10 Legislators who wrote the most letters to the DOD

Except for Senator Grassley, many of the legislators who most frequently wrote letters to the DOD were either Veterans and/or members of the Armed Services committee or the Appropriations committee. At this moment, a majority of the letters written by the top legislators are letters written on behalf of constituents. As new observations are implemented, I expect constituent letters to still be the highest, but I expect policy/oversight letters as well as letters on behalf of businesses to slowly trickle in due to the logs we have from the DOD_USACE agency as well as the DOD_OIG/DOD_OSDJS agencies.

Table 2: Legislators who wrote the most letters to DOD

bioname	party	chamber	cqlabel	committees
GRASSLEY, Charles Ernest	(R)	Senate	(IA)	AGRICULTURE BUDGET FINANCE JUDICIARY TA
FORBES, J. Randy	(R)	House	(VA-04)	ARMED SERVICES JUDICIARY
McCAIN, John Sidney, III	(R)	Senate	(AZ)	ARMED SERVICES HOMELAND SECURITY INDIAN
NELSON, Clarence William (Bill)	(D)	Senate	(FL)	ARMED SERVICES COMMERCE FINANCE AGING
HUNTER, Duncan Duane	(R)	House	(CA-50)	ARMED SERVICES EDUCATION TRANSPORTATION
PELOSI, Nancy	(D)	House	(CA-08)	SPEAKER
McCASKILL, Claire	(D)	Senate	(MO)	ARMED SERVICES COMMERCE HOMELAND SECUR
OBEY, David Ross	(D)	House	(WI-07)	APPROPRIATIONS
WOLF, Frank Rudolph	(R)	House	(VA-10)	APPROPRIATIONS
WITTMAN, Robert J.	(R)	House	(VA-01)	ARMED SERVICES NATURAL RESOURCES

Table 3: Policy Categories within Legislators’ Letters to the DOD

bioname	party	chamber	TYPE	cqlabel	committees
GRASSLEY, Charles Ernest	(R)	Senate	NA	(IA)	AGRICULTURE BUDGET FINANCE JUDICIARY
FORBES, J. Randy	(R)	House	NA	(VA-04)	ARMED SERVICES JUDICIARY
WEBB, James H. (Jim)	(D)	Senate	NA	(VA)	ARMED SERVICES FOREIGN RELATIONS
McCASKILL, Claire	(D)	Senate	NA	(MO)	ARMED SERVICES COMMERCE HOMELAND SECURITY
NELSON, Clarence William (Bill)	(D)	Senate	1	(FL)	ARMED SERVICES COMMERCE FINANCE
PELOSI, Nancy	(D)	House	6	(CA-08)	SPEAKER
BOOZMAN, John	(R)	Senate	1	(AR)	AGRICULTURE APPROPRIATIONS ENVIRONMENT
OBEY, David Ross	(D)	House	6	(WI-07)	APPROPRIATIONS
TOOMEY, Patrick Joseph	(R)	Senate	1	(PA)	BANKING BUDGET FINANCE
GRAHAM, Lindsey O.	(R)	Senate	1	(SC)	APPROPRIATIONS ARMED SERVICES BUDGET
WOLF, Frank Rudolph	(R)	House	1	(VA-10)	APPROPRIATIONS

Table 4: Most Common Policy Areas

TYPE	n
1	3798
5	149
6	88
0	43
2	35
3	25
4	3

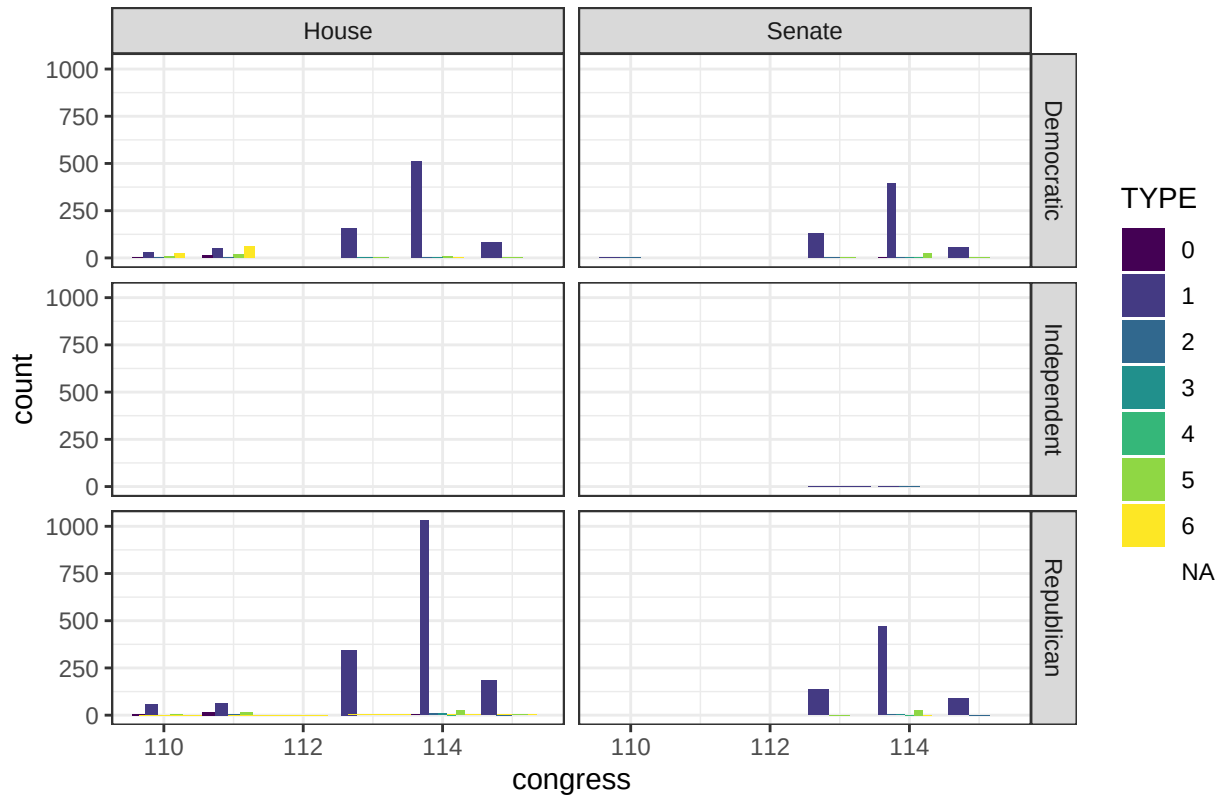
114th Congress

According to the diagram below, currently, our data set shows that a majority of letters have been written on behalf of constituent issues. However, the 114th congress has 3722 letters. This the most amount of letters received by the DOD during a congressional term. One reason why this result may be showing at the moment is because a majority of the logs we have received from the DOD are from the 114th congress (January 2015-January 2017). Another reason why there is a large influx of letters from the 114th congress is because there were numerous scandals that were unraveled, mainly scandals regarding sexual assault and deficiencies with veterans receiving theirn health and discharge records. The tables below show that a majority of letters were written to the DOD with issues during the constituent's time in service, mainly issues that have the subject lines of pay during their enlistment or the process of being discharged and collecting their records afterwards.

```
d %>%
  ggplot() +
  aes(x = congress, fill = TYPE) +
  geom_bar(position = "dodge") +
  facet_grid(party_name ~ chamber) +
  labs(title = "Policy Category Counts amongst chambers and Congressional Years")
```

```
## Warning: position_dodge requires non-overlapping x intervals
```

Policy Category Counts amongst chambers and Congressional Years



```
d %>% count(congress, sort = T) %>% top_n(10, n) %>% kable(caption = "Letters from Each Congressional session")
```

Table 5: Letters from Each Congressional session

congress	n
114	3722
113	1384
111	704
115	700
110	682
112	443

```
d %>% filter(str_detect(congress, "114")) %>% count(bioname, party, cqlabel, committees, sort = T) %>% top_n(10, n)
```

Table 6: Top 10 Legislators who wrote letters in 114th Congress

bioname	party	cqlabel	committees
McCAIN, John Sidney, III	(R)	(AZ)	ARMED SERVICES HOMELAND SECURITY INDIAN AFFAIRS
NELSON, Clarence William (Bill)	(D)	(FL)	ARMED SERVICES COMMERCE FINANCE AGING
GRASSLEY, Charles Ernest	(R)	(IA)	AGRICULTURE BUDGET FINANCE JUDICIARY TAXATION
HUNTER, Duncan Duane	(R)	(CA-50)	ARMED SERVICES EDUCATION TRANSPORTATION
BOOZMAN, John	(R)	(AR)	AGRICULTURE APPROPRIATIONS ENVIRONMENT RULES VETERANS AFFAIRS
BURR, Richard M.	(R)	(NC)	FINANCE HEALTH INTELLIGENCE

bioname	party	cqlabel	committees
TOOMEY, Patrick Joseph	(R)	(PA)	BANKING BUDGET FINANCE
FORBES, J. Randy	(R)	(VA-04)	ARMED SERVICES JUDICIARY
MURRAY, Patty	(D)	(WA)	APPROPRIATIONS BUDGET HEALTH VETERANS
RUBIO, Marco	(R)	(FL)	COMMERCE FOREIGN RELATIONS SMALL BUSINESS INTEL

```
d %>% filter(str_detect(congress, "114")) %>% count(SUBJECT, agency, sort = T) %>% top_n(10, n) %>% kable
```

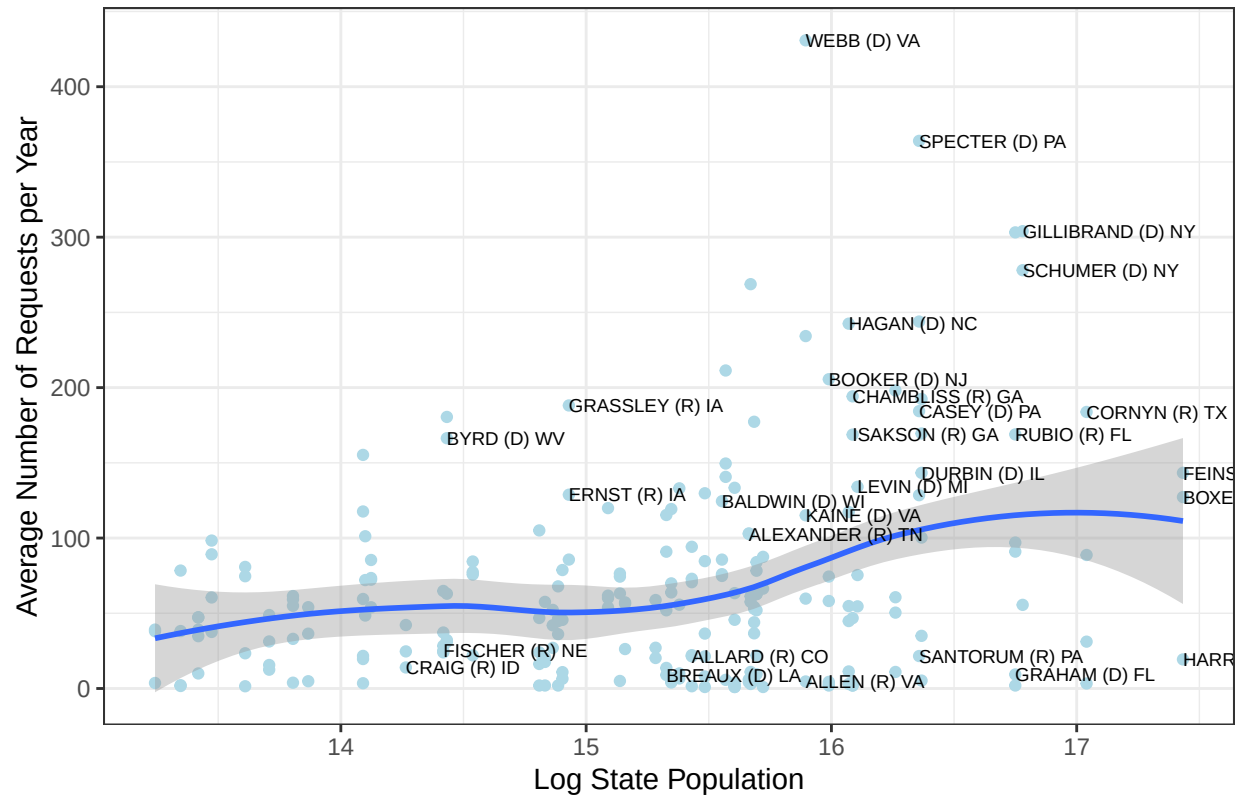
Table 7: Top 10 Subjects of Letters sent to DOD in 114th Congress

SUBJECT	agency	n
#NAME?	DOD_Navy	322
MILITARY PAY - ARMY, AIRFORCE	DOD_DFAS	191
NA	DOD_OIG	134
- REQUEST FOR UPGRADE OF DISCHARGE -	DOD_Navy	45
- DESIRE TO ENLIST -	DOD_Navy	44
- REQUEST FOR CORRECTION OF RECORDS -	DOD_Navy	34
- DISCHARGE UPGRADE REQUEST -	DOD_Navy	27
8 SENATORS CONCERNED ABOUT THE CONVERSION OF DeCA EMPLOYEES	DOD_DeCA	27
- REQUEST TO ENLIST INTO THE NAVY -	DOD_Navy	26
- EMPLOYMENT CONCERNS -	DOD_Navy	24

Senators Versus State Population for all Agencies

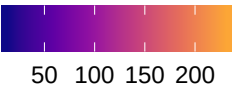
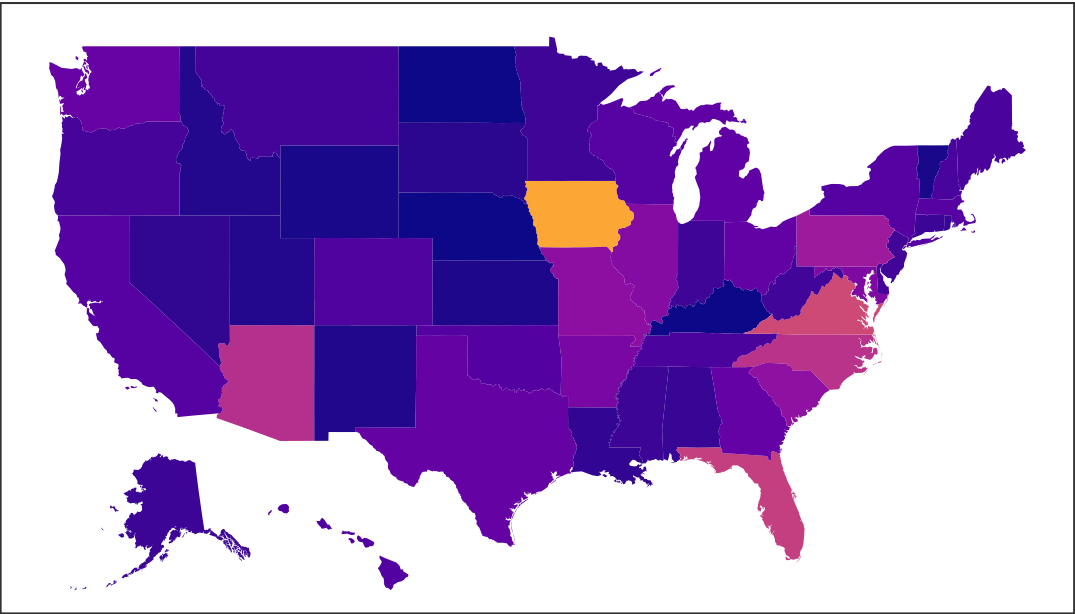
```
## `geom_smooth()` using method = 'loess' and formula 'y ~ x'
```

Senator Requests per Year by State Population



Senators Versus State Population for DOD

Total Number of Contacts from members of the Senate

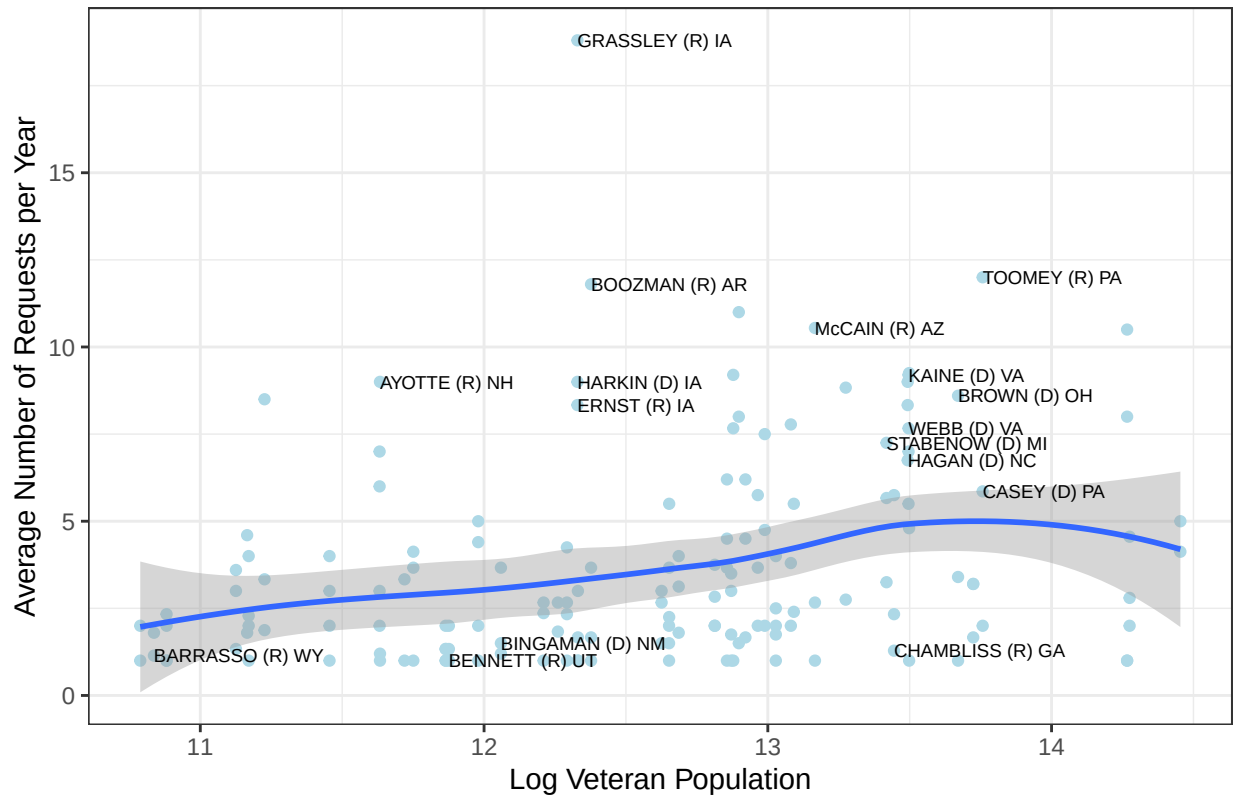


A choropleth map of the United States showing the percentage of the population aged 18 and over who are married. The map uses a color scale from dark purple (low percentage) to bright orange (high percentage). The highest percentages are concentrated in the Midwest, particularly in Illinois, Indiana, and Michigan, which are colored bright orange. Other states with high percentages include Ohio, Pennsylvania, and New York. The majority of states, including California, Texas, Florida, and most in the West and South, are colored dark purple, indicating lower percentages. Alaska and Hawaii are also shown in dark purple.

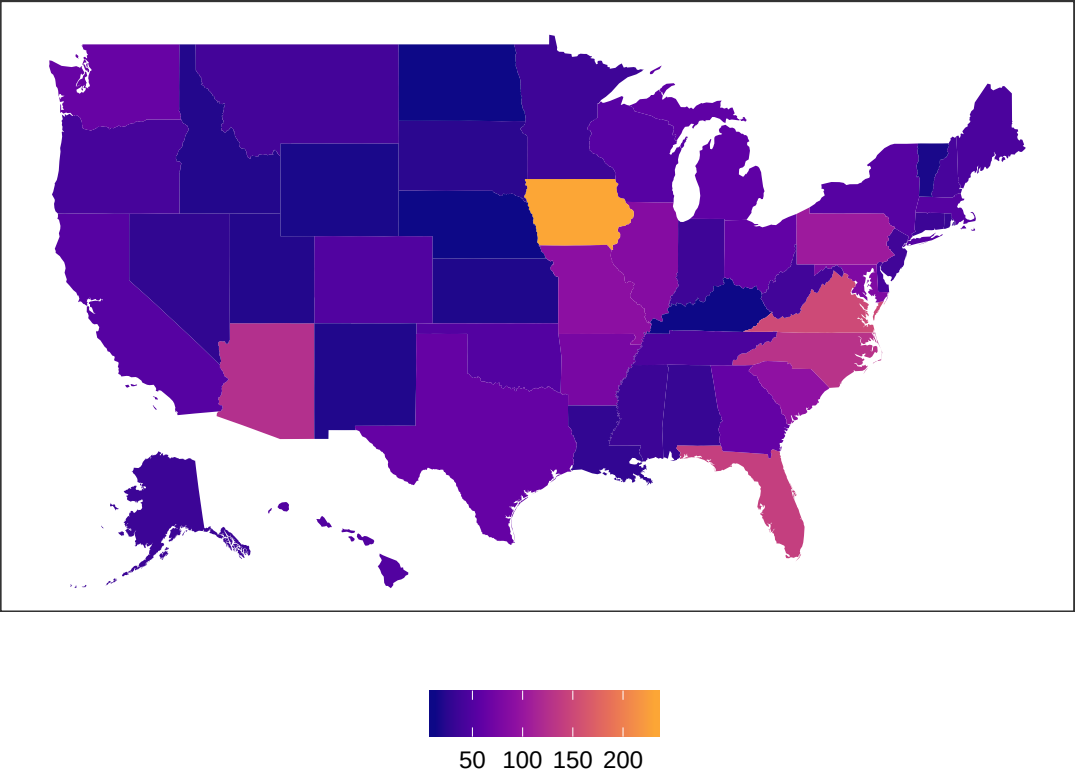
```
## Joining, by = "state"

## `geom_smooth()` using method = 'loess' and formula 'y ~ x'
```

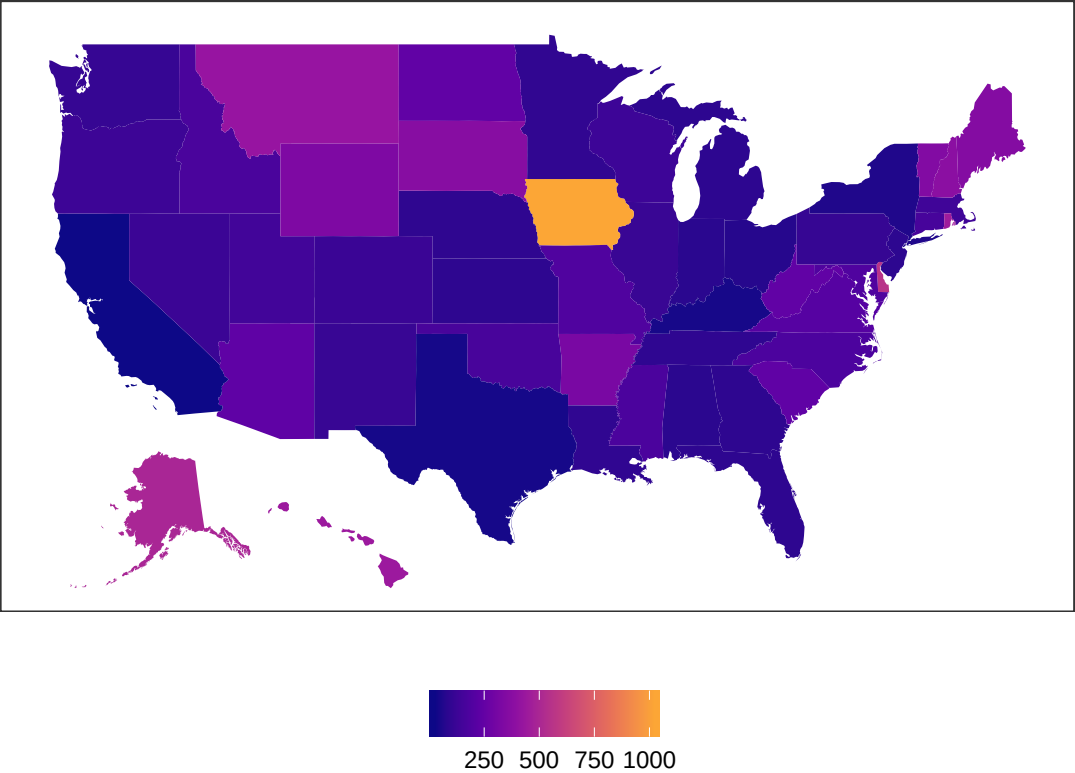
Senator Requests per Year by Veteran Population



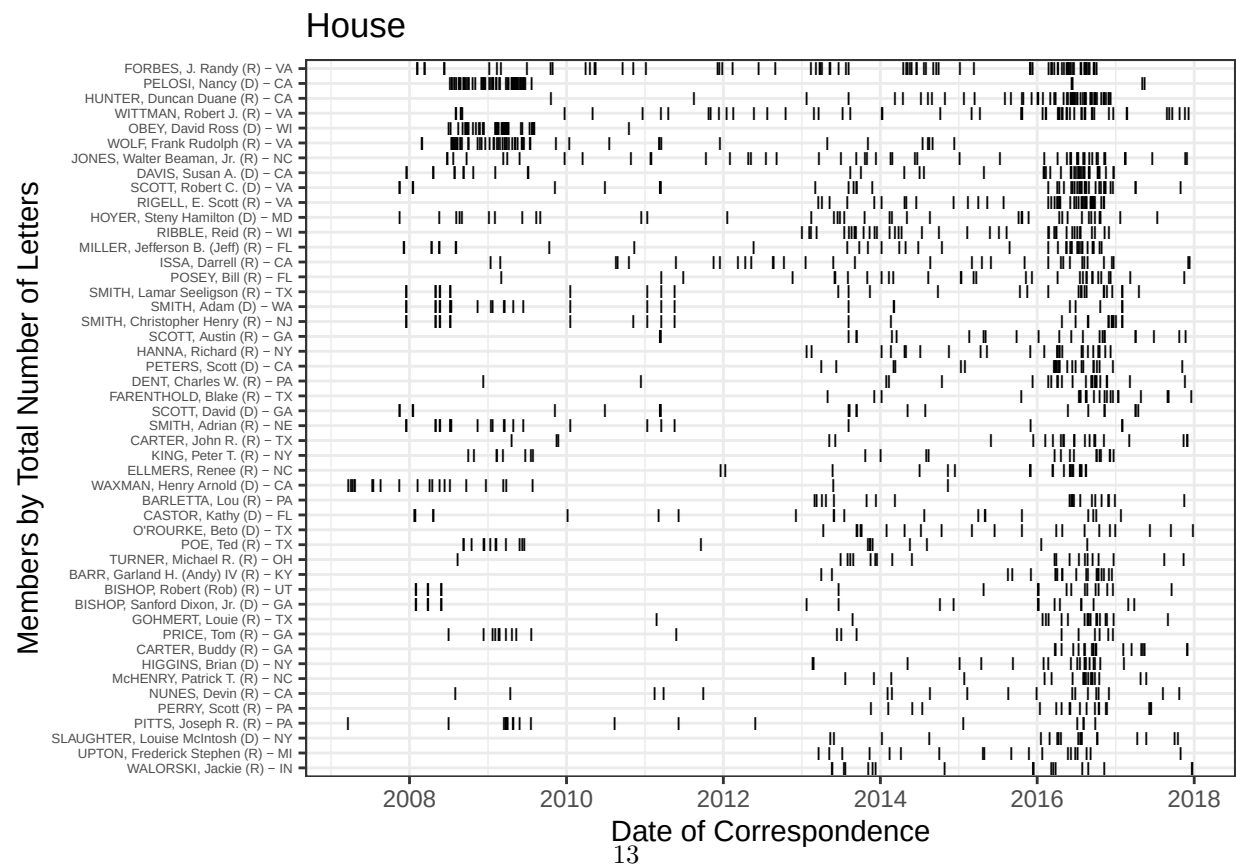
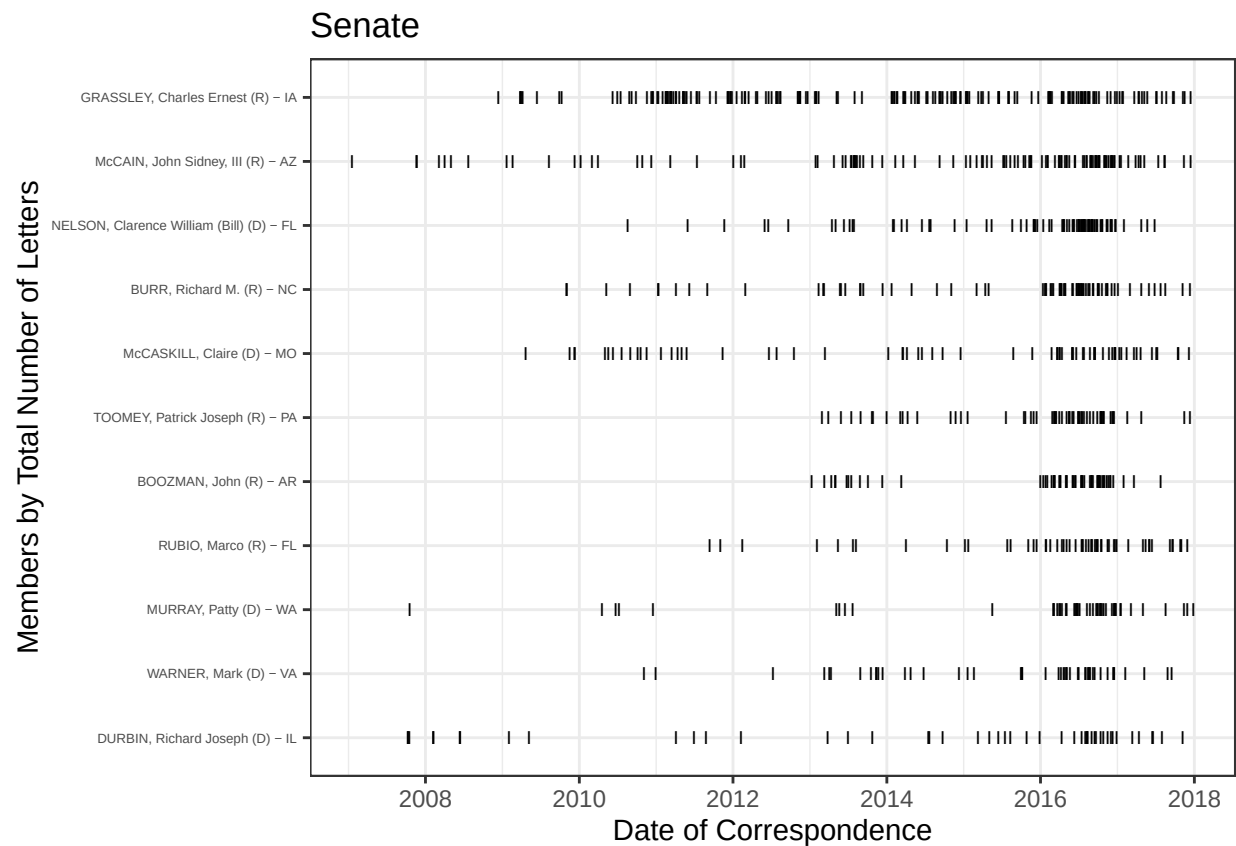
Contacts from members of the Senate per Veteran Population in State



Contacts Per Million Veteran Residents from Members of the Senate

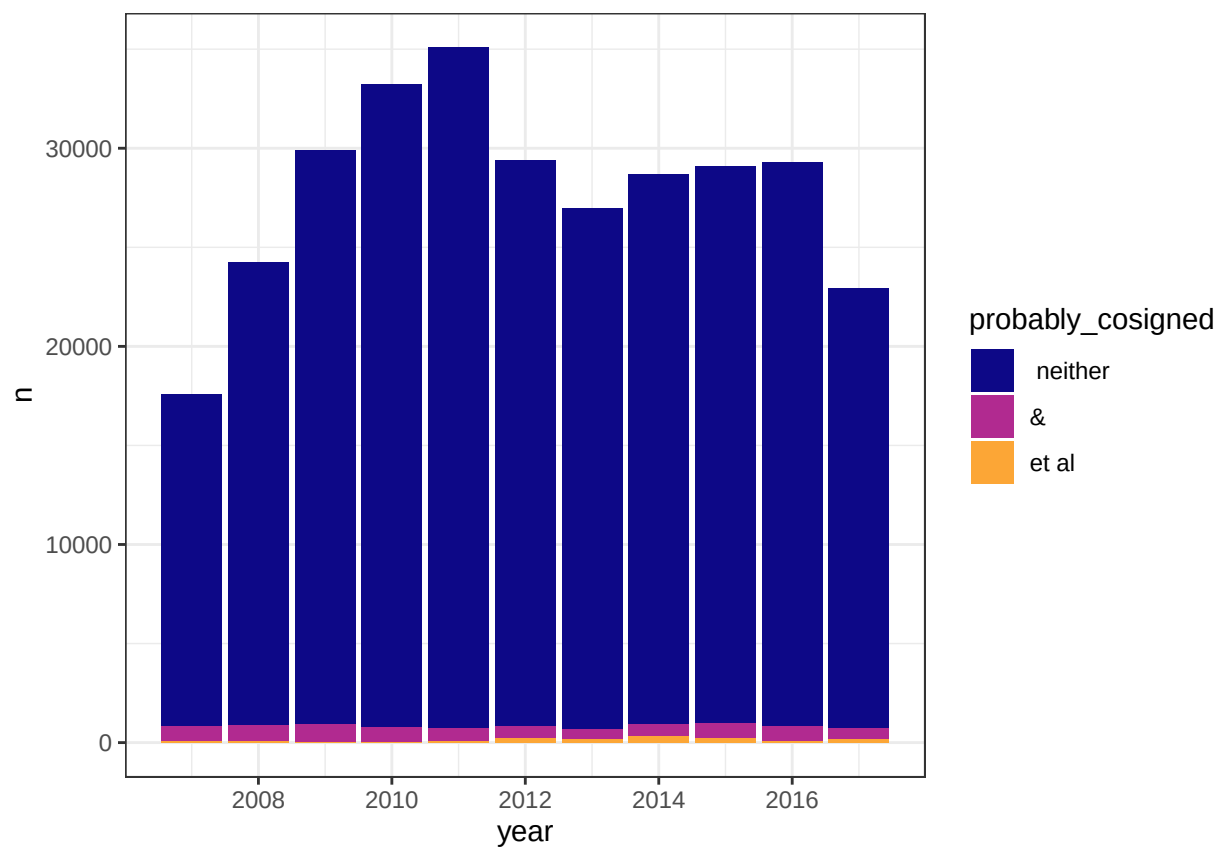


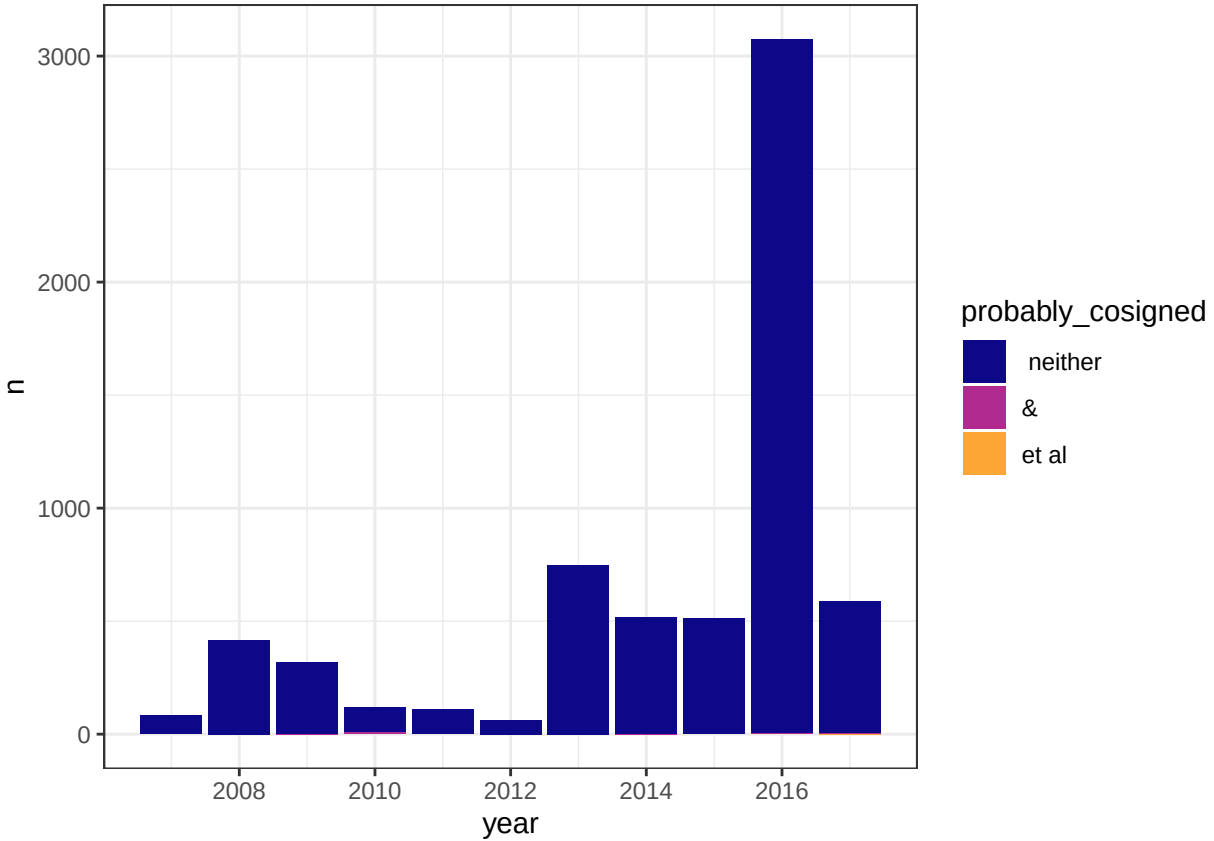
Members who contact DOD more than average:



Are letters to the DOD Cosigned?

A rough under-estimate based on whether “et al” or “&” appears in the summary:





Top Female Legislators who wrote the most letters to the DOD

Note, there are duplicates.

Table 8: Female Legislators who wrote the most letters to DOD

bioname	party	chamber	cqlabel	committees
PELOSI, Nancy	(D)	House	(CA-08)	SPEAKER
DAVIS, Susan A.	(D)	House	(CA-53)	ARMED SERVICES EDUCATION
PELOSI, Nancy	(D)	House	(CA-08)	SPEAKER
BALDWIN, Tammy	(D)	Senate	(WI)	APPROPRIATIONS BUDGET HOMELAND SECURITY
ELLMERS, Renee	(R)	House	(NC-02)	ENERGY
HIRONO, Mazie	(D)	Senate	(HI)	ARMED SERVICES ENERGY SMALL BUSINESS VETERANS
BROWNLEY, Julia	(D)	House	(CA-26)	TRANSPORTATION VETERANS
TITUS, Alice (Dina)	(D)	House	(NV-01)	TRANSPORTATION VETERANS
EDWARDS, Donna F.	(D)	House	(MD-04)	TRANSPORTATION SCIENCE
ADAMS, Alma	(D)	House	(NC-12)	AGRICULTURE ECONOMIC EDUCATION SMALL BUSINESS
GILLIBRAND, Kirsten	(D)	Senate	(NY)	AGRICULTURE ARMED SERVICES ENVIRONMENT FOREIGN AFFAIRS
SLAUGHTER, Louise McIntosh	(D)	House	(NY-25)	RULES

Table 9: Female Relevant Committee Members who wrote the most letters to DOD according

bioname	party	chamber	cqlabel	committees
DAVIS, Susan A.	(D)	House	(CA-53)	ARMED SERVICES EDUCATION
BALDWIN, Tammy	(D)	Senate	(WI)	APPROPRIATIONS BUDGET HOMELAND SECURITY
HIRONO, Mazie	(D)	Senate	(HI)	ARMED SERVICES ENERGY SMALL BUSINESS VETE
BROWNLEY, Julia	(D)	House	(CA-26)	TRANSPORTATION VETERANS
TITUS, Alice (Dina)	(D)	House	(NV-01)	TRANSPORTATION VETERANS
GILLIBRAND, Kirsten	(D)	Senate	(NY)	AGRICULTURE ARMED SERVICES ENVIRONMENT A
HERRERA BEUTLER, Jaime	(R)	House	(WA-03)	APPROPRIATIONS
DAVIS, Susan A.	(D)	House	(CA-53)	ARMED SERVICES EDUCATION HOUSE ADMINISTRA
HARTZLER, Vicky	(R)	House	(MO-04)	AGRICULTURE ARMED SERVICES
WALORSKI, Jackie	(R)	House	(IN-02)	AGRICULTURE ARMED SERVICES VETERANS

Multivariate Models

6. What Kind of Variate Models??–Pro-business/anti-business/Constituent vs. everyone else/ Party Explanatory #Party # constituent vs non constituent gender

Summary

Limitations throughout the Independent Study

Throughout the course of this independent study, there were a few limitations I faced. First of all, Google has increased their security as of November 2019, which means we no longer have access to many of the googlesheets packages we use in order to pull in data and organize it in an appropriate manner. Consequently, this means that a large majority of our data and observations have not been updated or accounted for in the last 6 months. Thus, the thousands of letters that I handcoded, as well as the the dates that I had fixed within the DOD dataset were not able to be used in this first draft of the paper. Furthermore, we are still waiting to receive logs from several DOD agencies which would further allow my analysis to be complete. Many of the agencies I handcoded primarily were agencies that deal with civilians or veterans and I predict that as we receive logs from the Air Force and the Defense Logistics agency, we may see more interesting cases regarding the relationship between businesses and the DOD. Lastly, a lot of my analysis is still yet to be done, since I had issues with pieces of code not working as well as identifying characteristics (for instance, gender) missing with some members of congress. There are also some duplicates in the data set that I am working on fixing/evaluating as to why they are showing up.

Future ideas to explore with this paper

In the future, I hope to continue my exploration with this topic by analyzing some different aspects to help evaluate the overlying question of how Department of Defense agencies interact with constituents and legislators. One major category I'd like to investigate is demographics, both within members of congress as well as within constituents who write to their congressmember. I am interested in exploring how a congressmember's veteran status can influence their constituent relationship. Furthermore, I am also interested in

seeing how gender, specifically a female veteran congressmember can influence the bills that she introduces in congress as well as the types of policies that she may support as a result of her Active Duty experience or experience from dealing with veteran/active duty constituents. Moreover, I am interested in looking at bipartisan relationships within legislators who actively work with the DOD as well as take a further look at the policies and bills that are implemented within the different policy committees within the house and the senate. I am interested in looking into members who contact the DOD more, relative to other agencies as well and potentially what the reasoning may be behind that. Lastly, I am also curious about the relationship between legislators and businesses and I'm curious to see if in the future I can investigate certain companies that write to congressmembers and what their motive is behind the correspondence. An appendix, with extra figures, letters, and a FOIA request will also be added on in a future draft of this paper.

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